the power of a true desktop but at least they offer portability and sufficient power for most work. The traditional laptop is one we're all familiar with– a hinged screen (up to 160 degrees), keyboard and touchpad.

Tablets / Phablets / Smartphones
These are essentially the same, just enlarged versions of each other. A flat slab of glass with a touch-sensitive coating that the user interacts with. All the magic that happens here is via the software rather than the hardware. Some of these, especially the tablets, come with keyboard docks that let you at least believe that you're doing something productive with these most indulgent of devices. These devices usually give us the longest battery life of any portable computer, but they only manage to do that because they do so little.

Modern designs
Hybrid devices
These have popped up from time to time but have recently started gaining in popularity with the advent of Windows 8 (read all about UIs in the second part of this story). These devices look like traditional laptops at first glance but have some sort of twist to them. Almost all have touch-screens, but some have screens that flip over by almost 360 degrees (the Lenovo Yoga), or screens that you can pull closer to yourself (the Acer Aspire R7) or just screens that can be reversed and folded onto the keyboard to force the device to function as a tablet.

The Microsoft surface PRO is a rare example of a hybrid laptop that is more tablet than PC. A device with the form-factor of a tablet, but with the power of a regular laptop. Unfortunately, the final verdict isn't yet out on that one.

If that wasn't enough, you have devices like the ASUS AIO Transformer, a device that attempts to give you the best of both worlds, Android and Windows. It also attempts to give you the best of both form factors, a tablet and a PC. It's an interesting concept that also hasn't gotten much traction.

Voice control
Voice control is suddenly picking up momentum. Siri first introduced herself to the world in October of 2011. Her voice was the promise of a future world where your voice would have power. One word (more actually) from you and all that you wanted would be at your fingertips. That vision has not turned into a reality yet but the big three, Google, Apple and Microsoft have made great strides in this area and are working as fast as possible to seamlessly integrate voice control into all their products and services. Devices like Google's Moto X for example, have a dedicated chip just for processing innumerable voice commands.

Gesture input
Another field that is garnering a lot of attention but is yet to show something truly concrete for the masses. This technology is still in its infancy with only something like the Kinect giving us a vision of what the future can be like (we're not counting the Wii here as it's nowhere near as flexible as the Kinect). The next-gen consoles have showcased their implementations of gesture-based games and interfaces to much acclaim and it won't be long before robotic arm gestures are so ingrained into our lives that we'll be using them in our day-to-day interactions with each other.

In all the cases mentioned above, it's the software that is the main limiting factor. UIs have still not evolved enough to meet our ever-changing needs and once it does, we won't even know. It'll be so well implemented that we'll take to them like a duck takes to water and we'll completely forget that the past was different. Till then, we've got our old classics to fall back on.

PC(future)=?
So what is the PC of the future? There are so many Permutations and Combinations of the various components involved. Do you need a keyboard or not? What defines a seamless experience according to you? Is it to be a single device that lets you do everything while giving you everything that you want? Is the ultimate PC a device that is so flexible it learns and adapts to your needs, the ultimate in Personal Computing? Maybe. Only time will tell. Join us as we explore the possibilities and potentials of PC design in the following chapters.